> they are nevertheless very civil and meek in their conversation, according to the custom of that country.

What Nieuhof noted but failed to fully understand were two defining characteristics of Nair culture: polyandry and snake-worship. Elsewhere in India men of their status took several wives, but not the Nairs. ‘Women in this point have got the start of the men,’ Nieuhof noted, ‘they being permitted to have three husbands at once … As often as any of them come to visit her, he leaves his arms at her door, a sign that neither of the other two must come in, for fear of disturbing the first. From hence the poorer sort reap the benefit, for they have the use of the wife, yet contribute only a third part towards the maintaining of the family.’ What Nieuhof had missed was that this was a matrilineal society, where it was the women who owned and inherited property.

As to snakes, Nieuhof noticed the particular devotion the Nairs paid to ‘serpents’, but then went on to say, quite wrongly, that they did so because they considered them ‘as evil spirits, made by God to torment mankind for their sins’. He failed to grasp the significance in rural India of the *Naag*, in the form of the hooded cobra *Naja raja* with its potentially fatal bite, its annual shedding of its skin and its apparent disappearance and reappearance before and after the monsoon. Snake-worship is still practised in many corners of India but nowhere more so than in Kerala, where carved images of cobras can be seen at virtually every wayside shrine (see illustration), and where a number of temples are dedicated to Nagaraja, the king of the snakes, the most famous being the Mannarasala Sree Nagaraja temple at Haripad, on the coast south of Alleppey. Until quite recently most Nair households maintained a grove of trees in the south-western corner of their gardens for their cobra, which all members of the family revered and fostered as guardian and protector.